

A SEISMIC SHIFT

The overwhelming victory of the Maoists may bring stability to the Himalayan kingdom and even present India with a unique opportunity to look at its decades-old policy in a new light



REACHING OUT:
Prachanda after
his victory

AP PHOTO/D WRAY

■ **By Damakant Jayshi in Kathmandu and Saurabh Shukla in Delhi**

Nepal has just experienced a seismic shift after the April 10 constituent assembly elections by giving former guerrillas—the Communist Party of Nepal (Maoist)—a decisive mandate, indicating that the time may finally be up for the world's only Hindu King, Gyanendra. Of the 220 of 240 seats under the first-past-the-post electoral system, the results of which were declared on April 16, CPN (M) bagged 119. The other two big parties, Nepali Congress (NC) and the CPN (Unified Marxist Leninist) were trailing with 33 and 31 seats, respectively. The former guerrillas are also leading the

count for 335 seats under the proportional representation system by bagging nearly 33 per cent of the votes counted so far.

For a party that waged a “people’s war” from 1996-2006 and was dubbed a group of terrorists by the Nepali government just two years ago, this is a big achievement. Though the election is primarily for re-writing a new constitution in the next two years, a new (coalition) government with CPN (M) at its helm is a foregone conclusion as the lat-

ter has already staked its claim for leadership of the future government. Even if the NC and the CPN (UML) decide to remain part of the coalition government with a token presence, the Maoists are likely to head key ministries—finance, defence, home and foreign—for the first time. It is a prospect that is inviting much speculation. “Since they have had a successful revolution and have taken everyone by surprise with their unexpected election victory, who knows


India will have to convince Maoists about forging closer ties and keep China at bay.